

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Sharpie maker Newell** Brands found a way to manufacture the marker competitively in the U.S., writing a playbook for producing low-cost, high-volume goods domestically. **A1**
- ◆ **OpenAI's Sam Altman** embarked on a global fundraising and supply-chain campaign, seeking partners that can help meet the ChatGPT maker's insatiable demand for computing capacity. **B1**
- ◆ **OpenAI is changing** its handling of copyright works in Sora, its AI video-generation app, to give copyright holders more control over how their characters are used. **B3**
- ◆ **Some 100,000** federal workers came off the government's payroll last week, the latest bit of unwelcome news for the softening U.S. labor market. **A2**
- ◆ **OPEC and its allies** agreed on a restrained oil output increase on par with earlier moves, a bet that the group can eke out more revenue without causing prices to crash. **B3**
- ◆ **Four days after** Asahi Group was targeted by a cyberattack, production at many of the brewer's plants in Japan remained offline. **B3**
- ◆ **Competing claims** to First Brands' assets point to questions and risks surrounding the sources of supply-chain finance. **B3**
- ◆ **Sports investment** specialist Arctos set up a new business line to connect qualified high-net-worth investors with professional-sports-ownership opportunities. **B5**

World-Wide

- ◆ **Delegations from the U.S., Israel, Hamas and Middle Eastern countries** are set to meet in Egypt for talks that could pave the way for a cease-fire in Gaza and the release of hostages, but ending the war remains a more distant goal. **A1, A7-8**
- ◆ **The federal government** shutdown is unrolling as a partisan staring contest, lacking for now the political or practical consequences that would create pressure to break the impasse. **A1**
- ◆ **China has exploited** a hidden funding conduit to pay Iran for its oil in the face of U.S. sanctions that make such settlements all but impossible. **A1**
- ◆ **The Pentagon said** about 200 members of the California National Guard who were under federal control were being reassigned to Portland, Ore., a day after a judge blocked the Trump administration from deploying Oregon troops. **A3**
- ◆ **The Supreme Court** in its new term will hear cases that could shape the Trump presidency, U.S. elections and transgender rights. **A3**
- ◆ **Jury selection** was scheduled to begin in the case of a Trump supporter accused of orchestrating a straw-donor scheme to benefit Trump's unsuccessful 2020 re-election bid. **A4**
- ◆ **France's new prime minister** named a government, bringing back former Finance Minister Bruno Le Maire to serve at the defense ministry and leaving other key positions largely unchanged. **A18**

JOURNAL REPORT
Investing Monthly:
Should you invest in private equity in your 401(k)? **R1-6**

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Hostage families and supporters hold a prayer rally in Tel Aviv calling for the end to the war in Gaza ahead of cease-fire talks.

Meetings Aimed at Cease-Fire In Gaza Set to Start in Egypt

U.S., Israel, Hamas
Mideast delegations
seek hostage deal;
ending war is elusive

Delegations from the U.S., Israel, Hamas and Middle Eastern countries are set to meet on Monday in Egypt for

*By Anat Peled
in Tel Aviv
and Summer Said
in Dubai*

highly anticipated talks that could pave the way for a cease-fire in Gaza and the release of hostages. But ending the nearly two-year-old war remains a more distant goal.

The parties meeting in Cairo will try to come to agreements over key points, including Israeli military withdrawal lines in Gaza and the names of high-profile Palestinian prisoners to be released in exchange for the remaining 48 hostages, including as many as 20 that Israel believes to be alive. Even if those talks succeed, however, they won't immediately end the conflict, U.S. officials acknowledge.

President Trump said on Truth Social on Sunday that the talks were "proceeding rapidly" in the lead-up to Monday's meeting. "I am told that the first phase should be completed this week, and I am asking everyone to MOVE FAST," he said.

Asked on Sunday on NBC whether the negotiations indicate the end of the war in Gaza, Secretary of State Marco Rubio said, "Well, not yet. There's some work that remains to be done."

Rubio said the path to bringing the conflict to a close will come in two phases: The first includes the coming meetings and working out logistics of the hostage release. "But that work is happening even as I speak to you this very moment," he said.

The second, harder, part is working out what happens in Gaza after Israel withdraws to the agreed-upon lines, Rubio said. The plan includes creating a Palestinian technocratic leadership in Gaza.

"You can't set up a government structure in Gaza that's not Hamas in three days," he said. "I mean, it takes some time."

Trump, who has pressured all sides to come to the table, appeared optimistic about the initial talks. "We'll see how it turns out," he said Sunday. "But I'm hearing it's going very well." On Saturday he had pushed for a quick resolution, writing on social media, "Let's get this done, FAST."

Trump is sending his top envoys Steve Witkoff and

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- ◆ **Hamas grapples with plan to end conflict**..... **A7**
- ◆ **Gazans' message to Hamas: End war now**..... **A8**

Parties Dig In, Await Pain From Shutdown

Pressure to resolve stalemate expected to build once workers start missing checks

*By RICHARD RUBIN
AND SIOBHAN HUGHES*

WASHINGTON—The federal government shutdown is dragging toward its second week in a partisan staring contest, lacking for now the political or practical consequences that would create enough pressure to break the impasse.

All signs point to another week of posturing and repeat Senate votes that fail to get the 60 votes needed to reopen the government. Congressional leaders in both parties insist that they have the upper hand and that the other side bears the blame for the shutdown.

"Right now, we're at a stalemate," Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R., S.D.) said on Fox, urging Democrats to buck their party's leaders. "They'll get another chance on Monday to vote again, and I'm hoping that some of them have a change of heart."

Even if the two sides make progress on negotiating a deal, President Trump's approval is necessary to end the shutdown, and he has preferred mocking Democrats on social media to engaging with them in the standoff's first five days.

The White House has already paused funding for transportation and energy projects in Democratic-majority

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- ◆ **Federal buyouts darken employment outlook**..... **A2**
- ◆ **Jeffries looks past Trump's memes toward deal**..... **A4**

Sharpie Rewrites Low-Cost Playbook In the U.S.

By NATASHA KHAN

MARYVILLE, Tenn.—Tucked in the foothills of Tennessee's Smoky Mountains is a factory that has figured out a way to manufacture in America that is cheaper, quicker and better.

It is the home of a famous American writing implement: the Sharpie marker. Pen barrels whirl along automated assembly lines that rapidly fill them with ink. At least half a billion Sharpie markers are churned out here every year, each one made of six parts. Only the felt tip is imported, from Japan.

It didn't used to be this way. Back in 2018, many Sharpies were made abroad. That is when Chris Peterson, who was the CFO of Sharpie maker Newell Brands, challenged his team to answer a question: How could they keep Newell from becoming obsolete compared with factories in Asia?

"I felt like we had an opportunity to dramatically improve our U.S. manufacturing," he said. Peterson is now the CEO. And these days, most Sharpies—in all 93 colors—are made at this 37-year-old factory. Newell did it without reducing the employee count, and without raising prices. But to get to this place took close to \$2 billion in investments across the company, thousands of hours of training and a total overhaul of the production process.

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INSIDE



PERSONAL JOURNAL
Septuagenarian entrepreneurs leverage technology, experience and contacts. **A11**



ENTERTAINMENT
Taylor Swift's new movie brought in \$33 million despite little promotion. **B1**

Grown-Ups Ditch Happy Hour for Sack Races and Duck-Duck-Goose

Adults rediscover the joys—and aches—of their favorite elementary-school pastime

By XAVIER MARTINEZ

The two men were in a shouting match about proper twerking form.

They weren't at the club. They were standing in broad daylight in a Brooklyn park playing the "ping pong shake," a game in which they were to shake ping-pong balls out of an empty Kleenex box strapped to their waist. Lost in the heat of competition, they had interrupted a field day.

Across the country, adults are embracing their youthful side to the extreme, gathering in parks to toss water balloons, play tug of war and hop around in competitive sack races.

Many say they crave a return to simple, in-person fun after years of pandemic-era isolation. They're making field days the centerpiece of birthday celebrations and bachelorette parties.

"When you were in elementary school, what was your favorite day of the year? It was field day," said Nichelle Taft, who organized an 18-and-older field day in September in the Charlotte, N.C., area attended by about 70 people, including actress and comedian Sheryl Underwood.

But adult games come with adult complications. Age and alcohol can send a field day off the rails. Social media is full of

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Trump Jr.'s Friend Tries to Cash In

Gentry Beach stirs confusion abroad as he pursues billions in investments

The president of the Democratic Republic of Congo sat with a veteran U.S. diplomat recently in a hillside

*By Rebecca Ballhaus,
Drew Hinshaw
and Joe Parkinson*

villa overlooking Kinshasa to resolve a question that had been troubling him. A Texas investor named Gentry Beach was regularly touring Central Africa, trying to purchase mining concessions as part of an "economic diplo-

macy" campaign he credited to President Trump.

Beach had let it be known he was friends with Donald Trump Jr., showing what senior Congolese officials described as text messages with the U.S. president's eldest son, and their photos together. Did he speak for the Trump administration?

Thousands of miles away, Pakistan's government had been asking the same question. Beach—a groomsman at Trump Jr.'s 2005 wedding—

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China Finds Secret Way To Pay for Oil From Iran

By LAURENCE NORMAN
AND JAMES T. AREDDY

U.S. sanctions make it nearly impossible to pay Iran for its oil. China has figured out how to do it anyway, in an arrangement that has largely been secret.

The hidden funding conduit has deepened economic ties between the two U.S. rivals in defiance of Washington's efforts to isolate Iran.

The barter-like system works like this, said current and former officials from several Western countries, including the U.S.: Iranian oil is shipped to China—Tehran's biggest customer—and, in return, state-backed Chinese companies build infrastructure in Iran.

Completing the loop, the officials said, are a Chinese state-

owned insurer that calls itself the world's largest export-credit agency and a Chinese financial entity that is so secretive that its name couldn't be found on any public list of Chinese banks or financial firms.

The arrangement, by sidestepping the international banking system, has provided a lifeline to Iran's sanctions-squeezed economy. As much as \$8.4 billion in oil payments flowed through the funding conduit last year to finance Chinese work on large infrastructure projects in Iran, some of the officials said.

Iran exported \$43 billion of mainly crude oil last year, according to estimates by the U.S. Energy Information Administration. Western officials estimate that around 90% of those exports go to China.

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